



Canada



Life Lessons



Health



Self Improvement



Pain



Rising from the Abyss: Virginia McIntyre's Journey from Chronic Pain Patient to International Advocate

6 min read · Sep 7, 2024



Pratik Aggarwal

Follow



Listen



Share

President of People in Pain Network, Championing Change and Empowerment for Those Living with Pain Worldwide

The Start of a Long Battle

As I was wheeled into the operating room for what was supposed to be minor surgery, my mind wandered to thoughts of returning to work and enjoying the laughter and camaraderie with my women's soccer team. Little did I know, I would never play soccer again, and work was no longer on the horizon. The pain that followed blurred my future, shattering my hopes and dreams.



I used to be a marathon runner. While chronic pain still allows me to run, I can no longer play soccer or run marathons. This one is from a run I completed, proudly holding my medal!

In 2008, a workplace injury led to shoulder surgery, and what should have been a six-week recovery turned into a three-year nightmare.

My life was suddenly consumed by severe, unrelenting pain that left me absent from work, disconnected from my family, and isolated from life itself.

I was plagued by a constant, burning pain in my back as if multiple knives were repeatedly stabbing me. Even the sensation of clothing on my skin felt like rubbing razor blades across raw flesh.

Struggling Within a Broken Healthcare System

I quickly found myself at the mercy of a broken healthcare system — one that seemed ill-equipped to comprehend, let alone treat, the complexities of chronic pain. Each time I tried to share my story, I was met with disbelief and dismissal, deepening my physical and emotional suffering.

Pain was not something I chose; it invaded my life uninvited and refused to leave.

The search for a diagnosis became a nightmare filled with endless skepticism. Healthcare providers, along with those closest to me, struggled to believe my pain was real, leading to strained relationships and a growing sense of isolation. The emotional toll was almost impossible to articulate — so overwhelming that I often found myself sinking into depression, crying alone in despair. I felt like a yo-yo, being passed from one healthcare provider to another, desperately seeking validation that my pain was real.

Without the support I needed, I resorted to various attempts to numb the pain, but nothing provided relief. It was a vicious cycle — one that made me feel not only abandoned by the system but completely isolated from the life I once knew.

Loss of Identity and Career

Before the injury, I was a driven career woman, a mother, and a wife, effortlessly balancing work and family life. But after the surgery, everything came to a screeching halt. I was unable to work for nearly three years, during which time I was subjected to countless medical appointments, pain assessments, and skepticism from healthcare professionals who failed to grasp the reality of my condition. Their disbelief and insensitive remarks left deep scars, both physically and emotionally.

Frustration and Despair

The relentless pain led to anxiety, loneliness, and an overwhelming sense of guilt. I became physically, mentally, and emotionally exhausted, feeling increasingly hopeless as the system continued to fail me. My pain escalated to such unbearable levels that I began to spiral into depression and feared I was heading toward permanent disability.

As I cycled through various healthcare providers — including physiotherapists, osteopaths, occupational and massage therapists — and was directed by the insurance company to see a psychologist, my frustration grew with each new

attempt. Despite their efforts, all I encountered was false hope and a lack of positive outcomes.

Get Pratik Aggarwal's stories in your inbox

Join Medium for free to get updates from this writer.

Enter your email

Subscribe

☐ Remember me for faster sign in

Physiotherapists repeatedly prescribed the same exercises, only for me to be sent back to work, where I could barely manage a few hours before the pain became unbearable. This constant cycle left me feeling bullied and misunderstood, trapped in a system that didn't care to understand my pain.

Turning Point: The Diagnosis

Eventually, I was referred to the QEII Pain Management Unit in Halifax NS, which marked a turning point in my journey. The pain specialist there finally diagnosed me with chronic pain, myofascial pain syndrome, allodynia, and hyperalgesia. For me having a diagnosis reassured me I was not crazy and this pain is real.

For the first time, I felt heard and believed. The doctor acknowledged my pain and provided a regimen of treatments, medications, and lifestyle changes that gave me hope.

The QEII Pain Management Unit in Halifax, NS, marked a turning point in my journey, but by then, I was already deep in a dark hole of agony and despair. Accessing pain care in rural communities is a challenge in NS, Canada. For me to see a pain specialist I need to make a 1.5-hour drive each way, totaling 3 hours just to see a pain specialist.

Learning to Live with Pain

Acceptance of my condition didn't happen overnight, but with the guidance and compassionate care of the pain management team, I learned how to live with persistent pain. I started to regain control of my life, setting goals and focusing on my quality of life. Learning to self-manage my pain was a challenging process, filled with trial and error, but I was finally on a path to wellness.

For years, I felt silenced by the stigma and skepticism surrounding chronic pain. It wasn't until I attended my first Canadian Pain Society Annual Scientific Meeting (ASM) and participated in a storytelling workshop that I realized how widespread the suffering was and how inadequate the existing care and knowledge were. This pivotal experience ignited my determination to address these gaps. I founded the first local peer-led pain self-management support group, which has since expanded to six groups providing critical pain education and support, both in-person and virtually.



Supporting others with pain is my mission. Here, I'm presenting at the National Action on Peer Support session, focusing on collaboration and empowerment for those living with chronic pain.

Finding Purpose and Advocating for Change

Today, I still experience daily pain, constant fatigue and occasional flare-ups, but with the right mindset, a personalized pain management toolkit, peer support, and healthy lifestyle choices, I can live well.

Pain has changed my life, but it doesn't define me.

I've regained my confidence and self-esteem.

I am proud to have been living well with pain for over a decade.

While pain is a constant companion, it has also made me a better person — more understanding, caring, and non-judgmental.

Living with pain has taught me the crucial importance of prioritizing, planning, and organizing my activities to manage my condition effectively. I practice mindfulness, follow a regular exercise routine, and stay mindful of my diet. Joining a peer-led pain management support group has been invaluable, offering a space to learn, strengthen my pain management skills, and connect with others who share similar experiences. It's a place where I can drop my mask and openly share about my pain.

Pain is an invisible illness, and you never truly know what someone else is going through. But I am living proof that it is possible to live well with pain, and I am committed to helping others do the same.

Virginia McIntyre is the President and Executive Director of the People In Pain Network, bringing over 25 years of experience in diagnostic imaging to her role. In 2017, she transitioned into a patient partner and peer supporter, and in 2023/24, she became the first Canadian with lived experience to receive the prestigious Mayday Pain and Science Fellowship.

Virginia's dedication to improving pain management and raising awareness about chronic pain is evident in her active participation in numerous research projects and pain-related initiatives. She serves on several influential committees, including the Pain Canada National Advisory Committee and the US Association for the Study of Pain's PWLE Committee. Additionally, she chairs the Canadian Pain Society's Communication Committee and PWLE Committee.

As a public presenter, advocate, and educator, Virginia emphasizes the importance of pain resources and peer support. Her ongoing work as an international presenter and advocate highlights her commitment to advancing the understanding and management of chronic pain.

Support the People In Pain Network at www.pipain.com.

Find more about Virginia at linktr.ee/VirginaMcI

Canada



Life Lessons



Health



Self Improvement



Pain



Follow

Written by Pratik Aggarwal

31 followers · 15 following

Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.
